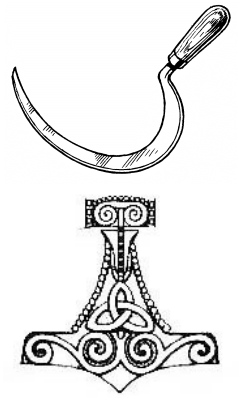


ES ALLELIEWEZIEL

26. GEHLING, 2013



ROBERT LUSCH (MIT DENKI ZUM BRIAN WEIS)
REV-D1

Honoring: Holle, Wudan, Der Butzemann

Order of Events: Schmaus, Discussion, Sege, Sammel

Intonation of the Runes

Each rune intoned thrice: Raidho, Jera, Kenaz, Ingwas, Mannaz,

Die Heiliching

*Sichel of Holle, heilich daer Aldaar un die Schtell
Beschitz uns mit der Graft vun de Ziewe
Bei Wudan un Frigg fer der Gemeeschaft zu baue
Bei Ziu un Zisa fer die Gerechdichkeet un der Fruchsfriede zu
erhalde
Bei Frey un Freya fer die Wohldaat zu schneide un zu sammle
Bei Nadd un Erda fer uns in de Belohninge vum Land un vum
Wasser zu frehe.
Bei Dunner un Siwwa fer es Volk vollzumechtige.
Bei der Fraa Holle fer es Volk zu erneire
Wie der Hammer schmittet die Sichel,
So die Sichel der Hammer fiedert.
'S iss es Lewesraad: zu saehe un zu schneide
Sickle of Holle, heilich daer Aldaar un die Schtell*

Heel! Heel! Heel!

Unser Zweck

*Heit sammle mir uns do, fer es Lewesraad zu drehe un aa fer die Haerrin Holle zu ehre.
Die Dunkelzeit kummt yetz zu uns, un mir sinn heit am Sammle, um unser Leweskraft zu erkenne.
Heel zu de Ziewe!
Heel zu de Wichde!
Heel zum Land!
Heel zu der Gmeeschaft!*

Der Aaruf

Invocations to Holle and to Wudan will be made both in Deutsch and in English.

Es Opfer un Die Eed

If anyone has any oaths or offerings, present them now.

Die Heiliching vun de Opfer

Die Ausdeeling

*Darrich die do Gedrenke deele mir uns in de Heilich Grafte vun de Ziewe,
vun unsere Voreldre, un vun nanne.*

Der Sege

When pouring the libations, all say (choose either language):

*Vun de Ziewe zu der Erd zu uns
Vun uns zu der Erd zu de Gedder*

*From the gods to the Earth to us
From us to the Earth to the gods*

*'N Gschenk fer 'n Gschenk
Heele!*

*A gift for a gift.
Hail!*

Butzemannbrenning

The Butzemann's journey is complete, and his soul departs on the Wild Hunt.

Zum Schluss

Zu de Wichde

DISCUSSION TOPICS

Allelieweziel

I have seen a lot of discussion about Halloween on various lists, and I wanted to share the importance of October 31, which we call Allelieweziel, within the old Deitsch (Pennsylvania German) culture and in Urglaawe.

A significant volume of oral lore was passed on via practitioners of Braucherei (the traditional Deitsch healing and magical practice), particularly from those who maintained a Heathen worldview when it came to their healing of the souls of the departed.

Years ago, several of my colleagues conducted oral interviews of over 80 practitioners of Braucherei, and the notes that they took from the interviewees who carried Heathen or syncretic views provided a very interesting picture of the importance of October 31.

The first interesting element is the name of the event: Allelieweziel. Christian practitioners of Braucherei did not use this term. While we can translate the term's meaning, "the goal of all love," we have not found a corresponding term in other German dialects (if anyone knows more about this, please contact me).

The observance of Allelieweziel represents the transition from the light half of the spiritual year to the dark half. Holle's departure on the Furious Host (Wild Hunt) is reflected in the death of the fertility of the soil. Allelieweziel is the death phase of the life-death-rebirth cycle.

As Holle sets off upon the Furious Host, She is followed by an entourage of the lands spirits and the souls of the recently departed. Throughout the dark half of the year, Holle hunts for stray souls. As She finds them, they join the Furious Host until She brings them to her figurative mill to "grind" them into their next life. Practitioners of Braucherei also use traditional journeying practice to help seek out stuck souls to help them cross over to the mill.

As a principally agricultural people for centuries before migrating to North America, the ancestors of the Deitsch transmitted no information about going to the hall of any deity upon death; instead, human souls follow cycles similar to that of the crops that dictated their livelihood. As such, most Urglaawer belief in a rebirth of the soul within the family stream as opposed to Valhalla, etc.

Another aspect to the holiday is the recognition of sacrifices that males make for the good of the community. Traditionally, as winter set in, culling of herds, particularly males, helped to provide food for humans and conserve resources for the remaining herd. This recognition is underscored by the burning of the Butzemann, or activated scarecrow, by the end of Allelieweziel.

The Butzemann is created from the remnants of the prior year's crops and is ceremonially granted life on Grundsaudaag (Groundhog Day). He is charged with overseeing his "child" crops for the season. Similar traditions are featured in other cultures. Throughout the light half of the year, the Butzemann is treated like other wights. Offerings and gifts are given to him. Anytime between Erntfescht (the autumn equinox/harvest home) and Allelieweziel, the Butzemann is released from his duties and he is to be burned in order to free his soul to join the Furious Host. The "soul" of the Butzemann is not human; it is one of the crops from which he is constructed, but all living things in Braucherei tradition have souls that are part of the cycle.

It is considered very bad luck to keep an activated Butzemann after Allelieweziel. If the soul of the Butzemann were to depart on the Furious Host, his remaining shell is likely to be taken up by a baneful land spirit, who, now having physical form, would terrorize the countryside. I remember my parents telling me that if I did not get back into bed on Christmas Eve that the Butzemann would "get me." Similar stories turn up all over Deitscherei.

It is also considered bad luck to wear clothing that was on a Butzemann. People often give warnings about this a look askance; however, in the Colonial era, it appears that vagrants often walked the great distances from town to town seeking work. As their clothes began to wear down, apparently they would occasionally exchange their clothes for those on a Butzemann. For some reason that we have not yet been able to fully identify, this theft is considered to be of a higher Wurt payback than theft of food from farms, etc.

Prior to the Butzemann's burning, we are to show him some of the remaining crops from which the next Butzemann will be created. This is to thank him for his success and to ensure him that the lineage will go on. Then, as he is burned, he is to be taking with him all of the things that we wanted to banish from our spiritual lives, particularly things that were on our list of resolutions at the New Year. The pyre is to bring about the extinction of those negative aspects of our lives along with any gifts to the deities. As we watch him burn, we honor his work and reflect upon the year gone by.

The time between Allelieweziel and Yule is considered to be the darkest time: the time between death and rebirth. It is not a time to fear, but instead a time to recognize the need for change within the universe. The end of one thing is a beginning of something new.

The duty of each individual being, whether human, animal, or plant, is to strive to leave the world a better place for our descendants (and us in our next life!) than it was when we came into it. This is the goal of all love. This is Allelieweziel.

*Robert L. Schreiwer
Distelfink Sippschaft
October/Gehling 2010*

Masks and Costumes

Everyone associates Halloween with the masks and costumes that children wear during tricks-or-treats. These costumes, though, are actually representations of the spirits that have set out on the Wild Hunt, as Dennis just described.

The costumes serve multiple purposes, depending on which historical thread you follow. On the one hand, they may serve to keep baneful spirits from recognizing human sojourners.

Other historical threads from both the Celtic and Germanic lore indicate that the spiritual entities are capable of shape-shifting, and the masks thus also serve as a representation of that ability.

In still other historical contexts, the spirits of the recently deceased, along with many land spirits (known also as land wights) depart from this realm and follow a leading deity on the Wild Hunt. In the Urglaawe tradition, with its roots in Braucherei, this deity is Holle. Other Germanic traditions see Odin (or Wudan) at the forefront of the hunt.

In Urglaawe's oral history, Holle is followed by the entourage of spirits, and the masks and costumes represent this parade through the Dark Half of the Year, which runs from Allelieweziel (October 31) through Walpurgisnacht (April 30). Throughout this time, we used to see numerous parades consisting of masks and costumes. In the Deitscherei, or Pennsylvania Dutch Country, we historically had Allelieweziel in October, King Frost (of which the parade in Hamburg is but a faint shadow) in November, and "Belsnickeling" (which was actually the original tricks-or-treats time for the Deitsch) around Yule.

We then had Mummenschatz around the New Year, which is ultimately the root of the Mummers Parade. Pre-Christian festivals in early- to mid-February are still seen, in part, in Fasching and Mardi Gras. In many parts of Europe, Shrove Tuesday is the day for tricks-or-treats. And, finally, there may even be a link (although tenuous!) between the Wild Hunt and April Fool's origins in England.

And, finally, once Holle returns to the land on April 30, the last festival involving masks and costumes, particularly in parts of Germany and Austria, is May Day.

*Peter B. Schlegel
Distelfink Sippschaft
October/Gehling 2011*

Der Butzemann

The word "Butzemann" in Deitsch, or Pennsylvania German, is literally translated as "scarecrow." However, within the practice of Braucherei (also known as Powwow) and in Urglaawe tradition, a Butzemann is a scarecrow who has been spiritually activated by receiving the breath of life during what is called the Ceremony of the Corn. This ceremony takes place on Groundhog Day, which is also the day upon which we celebrate the female creative powers and motherhood.

The Butzemann is created out of the remnants of the previous years crop, and he is "born" to be the father of the coming year's crop. We place runes into his stuffing, or we stick them into his clothing. We sing a song to him about the Butzemann dancing around the house. We give him many gifts on Groundhog Day, and we also parade him around the perimeter of the property for which he will be responsible. He is given instructions as to how to tend to the land, including who is friend and who is foe.

He then is placed upon his perch, whence he will be able to stand guard. Folklore tells that Butzemenner will jump off of their perches and walk among the fields in order to scare away threats to his "children." We periodically give him offerings of milk, honey, incense, flowers, or other items to help comfort him on his watch.

Between Erntfescht (the Harvest Home around the autumn equinox) and Allelieweziel (Halloween), the Butzemann is released from his duties. Typically, around the time of Allelieweziel, his role changes. His need to guard the land is passed. He now takes on the embodiment of the sacrifices that males make for their families and for the community.

Beginning around this time of year, historically speaking, herders needed to retain as much food supply as they could during the winter for the females of the species. The Schlachtzeit, or the killing time, tended to result in the culling primarily of the males of the species in order to help to ensure that the females would have ample food to survive.

The Butzemann also becomes a messenger. He is told (or is given papers upon which is written) the things we want or need to banish from our lives. We then show him the seeds that will create the coming year's crops. Thus, he knows his lineage will go on. He is then set into a pyre and his ashes scattered onto the land. His spirit is now able to depart on the Wild Hunt.

So, what happens if an activated Butzemann is not burned prior to the end of Allelieweziel? Well, perhaps nothing, but Deutsch folklore is rife with stories of such Butzemenner wreaking havoc. Their spirits leave the shell and join the Wild Hunt, but the shell remains -- activated and open for a passing baneful spirit to take a physical form.

There are likely some folks in this audience who, as children, were told on Christmas Eve that the Butzemann would get them if they did not get back into bed! This is where the Butzemann has some relationship to the concept of the bogeyman!

Also, Braucherei oral lore states that it is the epitome of bad luck to wear clothes that had been on a Butzemann. For starters, if the Butzemann is still on duty, then one would have to steal those clothes. Not a good idea. If the Butzemann has been burned and his clothes are still around, then the energies that activated him may attract baneful entities, which could result in disasters!

Ironically, it seems that in the 17- and 1800s, there were many homeless people wandering the countryside, and they occasionally would steal the clothes from the Butzemann. Perhaps adding a bogeyman type of taboo to the guardian was intended to discourage theft!

Hail to the Butzemann!

Attuning Yourself to the Seasons

Allelieweziel ushers in the new Germanic spiritual year (as opposed to Yuul starting the new calendar year). Today the Dark Half of the Year begins. The term "Dark Half" sounds ominous and maybe even a little bit scary. However, balance and cycles make up a very large portion of the Urglaawe worldview. Seasons, particularly here in the temperate regions of the US, are an important part of the balance and cycle concepts.

In our post-modern world, we, as a society, have successfully removed ourselves from many aspects of the cycle of the seasons. We can get fruit all year round. Roads are plowed throughout the winter. Our jobs force us to be out and about all year long. Our discussion will delve further into this topic than this little blurb will right now. However, I wanted to mention that we are now in the time of asking ourselves what we can do to improve ourselves (spiritually, physically, mentally, in all ways) on our life's journey and of identifying what we need to banish from our lives in the next year.

The answers to those questions become the basis for resolutions that we set on the Twelfth Day of Yule. :)

Bannzettel

As Allelieweziel is the recognition of the end of things, it is an auspicious time in the seasonal cycle also to put an end (whether spiritually, physically, or emotionally) to things that burden us and keep us from progressing. For many of us, this is the time at which we should have achieved an important milestone in our oaths taken at New Year's. For others, a decision as to what to banish comes quickly.

One of the Butzemann's functions is to take these banished items with him in spirit when he goes up in flame. As the Butzemann is released from his duties, so must we release ourselves from the yokes around our neck that serve us no benefit at this point of our lives.

You're invited to write down that which you wish to terminate or ban on a slip of paper (Bannzettel: banishing charm ticket) and throw it into the flame with the Butzemann. While the Butzemann burns, you may also want to ponder the evolution of yourself through the various eras of your life, mentally casting the things that have held you back into the flame.